Statement of Qualifications

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1. Please provide a specific example in which you had to investigate a potential security incident. What was the outcome of the incident, and how did collaboration and communication affect the result of the incident (if at all)?

During my cybersecurity internship at Log(N) Pacific, I investigated suspicious authentication activity on a public-facing host in a lab environment. I queried the host's sign-in logs with KQL, projected the fields I wanted to review, and looked at both the successful and failed login attempts. When I filtered down to the failed attempts, I found close to 100 failed SSH logins, a clear brute-force pattern against password authentication.

Because it was a lab, that volume of automated password guessing was not unexpected, but it was still a real and exploitable attack surface that needed to be closed rather than ignored. As long as password login was exposed, the host would keep getting targeted, and a weak or reused password was all an attacker would need to get in.

Rather than just monitor it, I eliminated the attack vector. I reconfigured SSH for key-based authentication and disabled password login, which removed password guessing as a path onto the host entirely. With no password to crack, the failed-login attempts no longer posed a real risk. I also weighed the trade-off behind the fix. Where password login has to stay enabled, a complex passphrase of 16 or more characters makes password-list and dictionary attacks impractical, but removing password authentication altogether is the stronger control because it closes the vector instead of just making it harder to exploit.

This was an independent investigation, so collaboration was not a factor. Communication mattered in how I documented it. I recorded the query that surfaced the failed attempts, the reasoning for choosing key-based authentication over password hardening, and the outcome, so the decision was transparent and could be verified and repeated by someone else.

2. How would you prioritize competing requests from key stakeholders? Please explain your process and the potential impacts that may arise due to your decision.

When requests compete, I prioritize by urgency and impact rather than by who asked loudest or most recently. My first step is to quickly understand what is actually at stake in each one, what the cost of it waiting is, and whether there is a hard deadline or a risk that grows the longer it sits. Whatever carries the highest impact and the most time pressure goes first.

I used exactly this approach during my vulnerability management internship project. An authenticated scan returned around thirty findings across critical, high, medium, and low severities, and I could not remediate everything at once, so I sequenced the work by impact and ease of remediation. I removed the outdated third-party application driving the critical findings first, then worked through insecure protocol and authentication settings, down to the lower-severity items. The critical issues were cleared early and stayed cleared, and total findings dropped from around thirty to three across the cycle. Taking them in order of impact, rather than at random, is what made the effort effective.

The other half of prioritizing well is communication. When my decision means someone has to wait, I tell them where they stand and when I expect to reach their request, so the delay is understood instead of being a surprise.

The impact of getting this wrong runs both ways. Spend time on a loud but low-impact request first and a higher-impact problem, like an open security gap, sits exposed longer than it should. Even when the technical call is correct, failing to communicate the wait erodes trust with the people depending on you. Prioritizing by impact and staying transparent about the trade-offs protects both the work and the relationship.